

ENGLISH LANGUAGE PAPER 4

PART A Group Interaction

This blog entry appeared on an education website:

Great teacher = great results?

The great teacher myth is often presented as a simple equation: great teaching gets great results. Many people support it but it is completely wrong.

The great teacher myth sounds plausible. After all, children spend a lot of time at school and we spend a great deal of money on education. By the time they are 16, children have been at school for 10,000 hours, which is often said to be the minimum needed to master a skill. Surely teachers must be the biggest factor in ensuring that all this effort is worthwhile?

The key problem with this idea is when it comes to exams and learning, children are the ones who actually have to do the hard work. Unfortunately, much to the frustration of every teacher – and parent – in the city, children don't always do what they are told, or learn what we attempt to teach them. What's more, some children find school and learning easy and some don't.

Trying to teach anyone anything is difficult unless they actually want to learn, and can do so. Learning is hard work; it requires effort, repetition, practice, mental and physical exertion.

Does that mean that teachers don't matter? Of course it doesn't. They help and provide excellent support, but we should understand they are not the most important factor in educational success.

Your group has to prepare for a debate with the motion: "Good teachers are the most important factor in educational success." You may want to talk about:

- arguments for the motion
- arguments against the motion
- which side would be easier to argue
- anything else you think is important

PART B Individual Response

1. Would you like to be a teacher?
2. Do you think being a teacher is a good job?
3. What kind of students do teachers like?
4. What is the most important skill for a teacher to have?
5. Do teachers get enough respect?
6. What characteristics make a good teacher?
7. Does learning require hard work?
8. Have you ever been inspired by a teacher?